

# Retirement Service Evidence Pack

Synthetic evidence pack for prototype demonstration. All services, findings, figures and people are fictional.

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## 1. Executive project background

This pack is the onboarding and desk-research reference for the multidisciplinary team at HMRC exploring **retirement as a life event**. It is intended for new joiners — in particular the incoming service designer — and for anyone who needs the accumulated context of the exploration in one place. It gathers project background, the fictional service landscape, prior research summaries, subject-matter-expert context, operational constraints, the current assumptions register, and a desk-research inventory of guidance content. It is a reference document, not a findings report: where evidence exists it is presented as collected, and where it does not exist the gap is recorded rather than filled.

The exploration began as a short discovery in the spring, prompted by sustained interest across government in organising services around life events rather than around organisational structures. Retirement was selected as a candidate life event because it touches tax, pensions, employment records and income reporting simultaneously, because the citizen population moving through it each year is large and growing, and because internal contact-demand reporting suggested that the period around retirement generates disproportionate inbound contact relative to the size of the cohort.

The core team comprises a product manager (Nina), a user researcher (Maya), an interaction designer (Leo), a content designer (Alex) and an engineer (Sam). A service designer is joining the team as it moves from discovery into a first alpha. The team sits within a wider directorate responsible for personal tax services, and reports monthly to a programme board that also oversees two unrelated explorations.

The team has produced, alongside this pack: a retirement life-event journey map; a research workshop board from the most recent team synthesis session; a forty-response citizen survey; and a set of moderated user interviews, of which the first has been written up in full. Those artefacts stand on their own; this pack does not attempt to summarise or reconcile them. Readers are expected to consult the artefacts directly and to form their own view of how the material fits together.

Three working principles govern the exploration and this document:

- **Evidence is presented raw.** Summaries in this pack preserve the granularity of the original notes. Where two pieces of evidence sit uneasily together, both are reported.
- **The life event, not the transaction, is the unit of analysis.** The team maps citizen experience across a multi-year arc, from early planning through to established retirement, rather than within any single service.
- **Fictional throughout.** Every service description, statistic, quotation, named individual and guidance item in this pack is synthetic and exists only to support prototype demonstration.

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## 2. Why this work exists

Three pressures, all fictional but modelled on plausible conditions, motivated the exploration.

**Demographic volume.** In the modelled population, roughly 640,000 people reach State Pension age each year, and the annual cohort is projected to grow by around 9 per cent over the next five years. A further, harder-to-count group retires before State Pension age — through choice, redundancy, caring responsibilities or ill health — and interacts with tax and pension services on a different timetable. The modelled population also shows rising complexity per person: the average number of separate pension pots held by a person retiring this year is estimated at 3.4, compared with an estimated 2.1 a decade earlier, driven by more frequent job changes and the long tail of automatic workplace enrolment.

**Contact demand.** Internal reporting (fictional) indicates that citizens in the two years surrounding their first pension payment contact HMRC at roughly two and a half times the rate of the general adult population, across telephone,

webchat and post. The cost-to-serve of telephone contact is estimated at £7.80 per call in the modelled figures, against £0.14 for a completed digital interaction. The programme board's interest is not solely cost reduction: repeated contact is treated as a signal that something in the surrounding service landscape is not working, though the reporting available to the team does not say what.

**Cross-government life-events interest.** Other parts of government have run life-event explorations around birth, bereavement and starting work. Retirement has been repeatedly identified in cross-government forums as a candidate with high citizen impact and high organisational fragmentation: no single organisation owns the retirement journey, and the citizen must assemble their own path across HMRC, their employers, their pension schemes, and services run by other parts of government.

The exploration's remit is deliberately broad: understand how citizens experience the retirement transition across tax and income services, identify where the current landscape helps or hinders, and generate evidence-based opportunities for a future alpha. The remit explicitly excludes pension policy design, benefit entitlement rules, and the regulation of financial advice, all of which belong to other parts of government or to regulators.

### 3. Service landscape (fictional)

The following inventory describes the fictional service landscape a citizen moving through retirement may encounter. None of these services is real; the descriptions exist to give the prototype a plausible world. The landscape is fragmented by design of history rather than by anyone's intention: each service was built at a different time, by a different organisation, for a different primary purpose.

| Service area                    | Operated by                         | What it does                                                                                    | Relationship to this exploration                                               |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Personal tax account            | HMRC                                | Lets a citizen view their tax code, employment income records and tax position online           | Central digital touchpoint; most retirement-related tax tasks route through it |
| State Pension forecast checking | HMRC with another department        | Shows a citizen their forecast State Pension amount and qualifying record                       | Frequently the first digital interaction in early planning                     |
| National Insurance record view  | HMRC                                | Shows contribution history and gaps                                                             | Used when citizens investigate their forecast                                  |
| Workplace pension schemes       | Employers and scheme administrators | Collect contributions, send annual statements, pay out on retirement                            | Outside HMRC control; a major source of the paperwork citizens hold            |
| Personal pension providers      | Private firms                       | Administer individual pots, including small legacy pots                                         | Outside HMRC control; data reaches HMRC on provider reporting cycles           |
| Retirement guidance service     | Another department                  | Offers general guidance conversations about pension options                                     | Citizens are signposted to it; HMRC has no visibility of usage                 |
| Pension tracing service         | Another part of government          | Helps citizens find contact details for schemes they have lost touch with                       | Relevant to citizens with old or lost pots                                     |
| Telephone helplines             | HMRC                                | General and specialist lines covering tax codes, income tax queries and repayments              | Largest contact channel by volume in this life event                           |
| Webchat                         | HMRC                                | Assisted digital channel attached to selected online pages                                      | Smaller volume; availability varies by time of day                             |
| Postal correspondence           | HMRC                                | Letters generated by tax-code changes, end-of-year reconciliation and citizen-initiated queries | High volume around the transition period                                       |
| Employer payroll                | Employers                           | Applies tax codes to salary and reports pay to HMRC                                             | The mechanism by which employment income winds down                            |
| Pension payroll                 | Scheme administrators               | Applies tax codes to pension payments and reports them to HMRC                                  | The mechanism by which pension income begins                                   |

Two structural features of this landscape recur throughout the team's material and are worth flagging without interpretation. First, **the citizen is the only actor present at every touchpoint**; no organisation sees the whole journey. Second, **information flows between the actors on batch cycles** — provider reporting, payroll submission, letter generation — so the picture any one actor holds at a given moment can lag the citizen's actual circumstances by weeks.

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## 4. Retirement as a life event

The team frames retirement not as a date but as an arc of several years with distinct stages. The lifecycle model below is used across all project artefacts, including the journey map and the desk-research inventory in section 20. The boundaries between stages are soft: citizens move back and forth, skip stages, or occupy two at once (a person drawing one pot while still employed is simultaneously in transition and, for that pot, in the first year of receiving pension income).

| Lifecycle stage          | Indicative span                                  | Typical moments within the stage                                                                                             |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Early planning           | 10 to 3 years before stopping work               | First serious look at a State Pension forecast; counting up old pots; first annual statement read rather than filed          |
| Approaching retirement   | 3 years to 6 months before                       | Decisions about dates; conversations with schemes; tracing lost pots; part-time or phased arrangements agreed with employers |
| Employment transition    | 6 months before to first pension payment         | Final salary payments; notifying schemes; overlapping income sources; tax code changes as records update                     |
| First year of retirement | First pension payment to roughly 12 months after | First payments arrive; first tax code applied to pension income; first end-of-tax-year cycle in the new circumstances        |
| Established retirement   | Beyond the first year                            | Steady state; occasional changes such as a new pot coming into payment, savings interest, bereavement, or a move             |

Several properties of the life event distinguish it from transactional service journeys and shape everything the team has looked at:

- **It is slow.** The arc spans years, and citizens' attention to it is intermittent. A citizen might engage intensely for a fortnight and then not think about it for eighteen months.
- **It is assembled from fragments.** The citizen holds paperwork from multiple schemes, multiple former employers and HMRC, accumulated over decades. Loss of any fragment (a scheme's contact details, a statement from a job held in the 1990s) creates work.
- **It is emotionally loaded.** For many citizens the transition combines identity change, income anxiety and unfamiliar administrative territory. Research notes across the project record apprehension appearing even in interactions that complete successfully.
- **It rarely happens alone.** Partners, adult children, colleagues who "did it last year", and employers all appear in the team's material as actors in the citizen's journey, sometimes as helpers and sometimes as sources of second-hand information of variable accuracy.
- **Timing is imposed from multiple directions.** State Pension age, scheme retirement ages, employer notice periods and the tax year all run on different clocks, and the citizen must schedule their transition across all of them at once.

The team treats the stage model as a lens, not a claim about how citizens see themselves. No citizen in any research session has described their own situation in stage terms; they describe it in terms of jobs, birthdays, and specific letters or payments.

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## 5. Employment-to-retirement transitions

Desk research and prior project material identify at least six distinct patterns by which employment ends and pension income begins. The patterns matter because the tax and information consequences differ substantially between them,

while much guidance is written as if a single pattern — full-time work ending on a known date, followed immediately by pension income — were universal.

- **Cliff-edge retirement.** Full-time employment ends on a planned date; pension income begins shortly after. The administratively simplest pattern, and the one most guidance implicitly assumes. Even here, the handover between the last salary payment and the first pension payment involves employer payroll, scheme payroll and HMRC records updating on independent cycles.
- **Phased retirement.** Hours reduce over months or years, often with pension income beginning while employment income continues. The citizen holds multiple concurrent income sources, and their tax position changes each time the mix shifts. Guidance for this pattern is scattered across items written for "multiple incomes" generally.
- **Health-driven early exit.** Employment ends earlier than planned, sometimes abruptly, on medical grounds. The citizen may access pension income early, may have periods with no income, and is frequently dealing with the administration while unwell. Timing is not chosen and planning-stage guidance may never have been read.
- **Redundancy-driven exit.** Late-career redundancy converts a planned multi-year glide into an immediate decision. Lump-sum payments, notice pay and pension decisions arrive together. The citizen enters the transition stage without having passed through approaching-retirement preparation.
- **Self-employment tail.** Employment ends but self-employed or freelance income continues at low volume — consultancy, a market stall, seasonal work. The citizen straddles employed-pension and self-employed reporting worlds, and encounters guidance from both, written by different teams in different registers.
- **Caring interruption.** Employment ends or reduces to provide care, sometimes years before any pension can be drawn. The citizen's contribution record, and therefore their forecast, is affected in ways they may not discover until early planning begins — if it begins.

Across all patterns, three administrative moments recur in the team's material as points where the citizen's world and the system's records must synchronise: the final employment payment, the first pension payment, and the first end-of-tax-year cycle after the change. Each synchronisation involves data moving between employer, scheme and HMRC on batch timetables, and each generates correspondence.

A further complication is that "retirement" as the citizen experiences it and "retirement" as any given system records it are different events on different dates. A scheme records the date a pot comes into payment; an employer records a leaving date; HMRC's records reflect whichever reports have arrived. Prior research notes include citizens who consider themselves retired while records show them employed, and the reverse.

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## 6. Citizen groups and circumstances

Prior research and desk analysis have led the team to work with a set of citizen circumstances rather than demographic segments. The same person may occupy several circumstances at once, and circumstances predict information needs better than age or income in the material gathered so far. The list below is a working inventory, not a validated segmentation.

| Circumstance                   | Description                                                                                                         | Illustrative consequences for the journey                                                                                |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Multiple small pots            | Two to six pots accumulated across job changes, often including one or more the citizen cannot locate paperwork for | Tracing work; statements arriving from several administrators on different cycles; totals that must be assembled by hand |
| Single-scheme career           | One long employment with one workplace scheme                                                                       | Simpler paperwork; expectations set entirely by one scheme's communications style                                        |
| Phased or part-time transition | Concurrent employment and pension income                                                                            | Multiple simultaneous tax codes; position changes whenever hours change                                                  |
| Health-driven early retirement | Unplanned exit on medical grounds                                                                                   | Compressed decisions; administration handled while unwell or by a family member                                          |

| Circumstance                     | Description                                                | Illustrative consequences for the journey                                                                                 |
|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Shift and variable-hours workers | Irregular income history                                   | Records and forecasts harder to interpret against lived experience of earnings                                            |
| Self-employed spells             | One or more periods of self-employment in the work history | Small personal pots; familiarity with reporting obligations but not with pension payroll                                  |
| Working-partner households       | One partner retired, one still working                     | Household-level decisions; the retired partner often navigates using the working partner's or a friend's prior experience |
| Carers                           | Employment reduced or ended for caring                     | Contribution gaps; retirement administration competing with caring workload                                               |
| Digitally confident              | Comfortable with apps and online accounts in daily life    | Digital-first behaviour in this journey cannot be assumed from digital confidence elsewhere; see sections 8 and 12        |
| Digitally excluded               | No internet access, no devices, or no confidence online    | Phone and post are the entire service; intermediaries (family, friends, advice organisations) often involved              |
| Recently bereaved                | Managing a deceased partner's pensions alongside their own | Two journeys at once; bereavement-related guidance intersects retirement guidance in search results                       |
| Planned-abroad retirees          | Intending to retire outside the UK                         | Additional payment and tax arrangements; a small minority with disproportionately complex questions                       |

Points the team holds about this inventory, recorded here without resolution:

- The inventory is derived from small-sample research and desk work; the relative size of the groups in the population is unknown.
- Circumstance often becomes visible to the citizen only when it causes a problem. Several research participants did not know how many pots they held until prompted to count.
- Guidance content is largely organised by topic (tax, contributions, refunds) rather than by circumstance, so a citizen must translate their circumstance into topic vocabulary before they can search. The desk-research inventory in section 20 records, per item, which circumstances each item silently assumes.

## 7. Existing service touchpoints

The table below inventories the touchpoints at which a citizen in this life event encounters HMRC or an adjacent actor, arranged against the lifecycle. It is a map of what exists, not an assessment of what works; assessments belong to the research artefacts.

| Touchpoint                         | Channel               | Lifecycle stage(s)                        | Initiated by | Notes                                                                              |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Annual scheme statements           | Post or scheme portal | Early planning onwards                    | Scheme       | Format and terminology vary by administrator; arrival dates spread across the year |
| State Pension forecast view        | Online                | Early planning;<br>Approaching retirement | Citizen      | Shows a weekly figure and qualifying-record summary                                |
| National Insurance record view     | Online                | Early planning                            | Citizen      | Reached from the forecast; gap years shown by tax year                             |
| Personal tax account               | Online                | All stages                                | Citizen      | Tax code, income records, and messages; sign-in required                           |
| Tax-code notification letters      | Post                  | Employment transition;<br>First year      | HMRC         | Generated automatically when a code changes; volume peaks in the transition period |
| End-of-year reconciliation letters | Post                  | First year; Established                   | HMRC         | Sent where the year's tax position needs adjustment                                |

| Touchpoint                        | Channel                | Lifecycle stage(s)     | Initiated by | Notes                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------|------------------------|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| General income tax helpline       | Telephone              | All stages             | Citizen      | Largest single contact route in this life event                        |
| Webchat                           | Online assisted        | All stages             | Citizen      | Attached to selected guidance pages; staffed hours vary                |
| Paper query and claim routes      | Post                   | All stages             | Citizen      | Used predominantly by digitally excluded citizens and intermediaries   |
| Employer payroll interactions     | Via employer           | Employment transition  | Employer     | Leaving processes, final payments, and end-of-employment summaries     |
| Scheme retirement packs           | Post or portal         | Approaching retirement | Scheme       | Option forms and decision paperwork; outside HMRC control              |
| Guidance pages                    | Online                 | All stages             | Citizen      | The content inventoried in section 20                                  |
| Retirement guidance conversations | Telephone or in person | Approaching retirement | Citizen      | Run by another department; HMRC receives no record of the conversation |

Observations recorded during the touchpoint mapping, held as raw notes:

- The citizen-initiated and system-initiated touchpoints interleave without coordination. A citizen may receive a scheme statement, a tax-code letter and an end-of-year letter in the same month from three different senders, each unaware of the others.
- Sign-in is the gateway to most digital touchpoints. Prior research sessions repeatedly recorded friction at identity verification for citizens whose documents (expired passports, no driving licence) do not fit standard routes.
- No touchpoint currently presents the citizen's position across all their income sources in one place; each shows the slice its operator holds.
- Letters are the only channel that reaches every citizen in the cohort regardless of digital access.

## 8. Findings from previous fictional research

This section summarises research conducted before the current phase. All studies are fictional. Findings are reported as recorded in the original notes; the team has deliberately not synthesised across studies in this pack, and readers should treat each study's findings as standing alone.

### 8.1 Spring discovery interviews (12 participants)

Twelve citizens between 58 and 70, recruited across the circumstances in section 6, were interviewed about their retirement journey to date. Recorded findings, as noted:

- Most participants could not state how many pension pots they held without consulting paperwork; two discovered an additional pot during the session while looking for something else.
- Paperwork practices varied from a single labelled folder maintained for decades to "a drawer with everything pension-shaped in it".
- Participants described the transition period as a sequence of letters and payments whose order they did not control and could not predict.
- Nine of twelve had asked another person for help at least once: a partner, an adult child, a former colleague, or "the woman at the community centre who used to work in payroll".
- Several participants kept every letter unopened-then-refiled in arrival order, treating the pile itself as the system of record.
- Timing questions ("when do I tell them", "when does it change") recurred more often in the notes than amount questions ("how much").

## 8.2 Contact-centre call-listening exercise (60 calls)

Two team members listened to sixty recorded calls (fictional) sampled from lines dealing with income tax and tax-code queries where the caller mentioned retirement or pension income. The exercise recorded observations, not categorised reasons:

- Callers frequently opened by narrating their circumstances at length before stating a question; advisers listened for the tax-relevant fragment.
- A substantial number of calls ended with the adviser confirming that nothing was wrong and no action was needed.
- Callers often had correspondence in hand and read from it; advisers often could not see the same document and worked from a different system view.
- Several callers stated they had already looked online before phoning. The exercise did not capture what they had looked at or what happened there.
- Advisers used workarounds — plain-language reformulations of standard letter text — that they had developed individually; two advisers described keeping personal crib sheets.
- Call lengths in the sample ran materially longer than the average for the same lines (fictional averages: 11.4 minutes against a line average of 7.9).

## 8.3 Autumn citizen panel (18 participants, 3 sessions)

A standing citizen panel of eighteen members, meeting three times, discussed retirement-related correspondence and services. Findings as recorded in the panel notes:

- Panel members brought examples of letters they had received. Reading them aloud, most stumbled over at least one sentence, and the group frequently debated what a letter was actually asking the recipient to do, if anything.
- One panel member described receiving a letter from HMRC that she had not been expecting, about a change to her tax position after her pension began. Her recorded reaction: she "assumed something was wrong" and did not open the letter for two days, then telephoned the same morning she opened it. She said she had done nothing to prompt the letter and could not tell from the envelope or the first paragraph whether she was in trouble. The note records the experience as she described it; the panel did not discuss it further.
- Panel members disagreed about how much contact from HMRC they wanted. Some wanted to be told about everything as it happened; others wanted contact only when action was required. The disagreement was not resolved and recurred in all three sessions.
- The word "final" in correspondence (as in a final statement or final payment) was flagged by several members as alarming in the retirement context regardless of its administrative meaning.
- Panel members widely assumed that HMRC already knows "everything" about their pensions and were surprised to hear that provider data arrives on reporting cycles.

## 8.4 Pop-up research at two community venues (26 short conversations)

Short unmoderated-style conversations at a library and a supermarket community room, with citizens aged 55+, produced quick-capture notes:

- Awareness of the State Pension forecast service was patchy; several participants confused the forecast with annual statements from their workplace scheme.
- Participants over 70 largely described their retirement administration as "done" and their current contact with HMRC as rare.
- Perceptions of HMRC ranged from "efficient once you get through" to "you only hear from them when something's wrong". Both perceptions appeared in the same session more than once.
- Six participants said they would "just ring" for anything pension-related; four of the six own smartphones and use them daily for other tasks.
- Two participants asked the researchers questions about their own tax situations, which the researchers could not answer; both were signposted to the helpline.

## 8.5 Previous desk review of complaints correspondence (fictional sample)

A review of forty complaint letters mentioning retirement, pensions or tax codes recorded recurring features without quantification: multiple contacts about the same issue; letters crossing in the post with citizen actions; and complaints in which the eventual resolution was that the original position had been correct all along. The review noted that complaint volumes in this life event are low relative to contact volumes, and cautioned against treating complaints as representative.

## 9. Stakeholder and SME context

The exploration draws on a network of internal and adjacent subject-matter experts. All individuals are fictional. The table records their perspective as expressed in stakeholder interviews, without endorsement; several perspectives conflict, and the team treats the conflicts as data about the organisation.

| Name            | Role                                | Perspective offered                                                                                                            |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Nina (team)     | Product manager                     | Frames the opportunity around contact demand and citizen effort; cautious about scope creep into pensions policy               |
| Maya (team)     | User researcher                     | Owns the research artefacts; emphasises that the current evidence base is small and early                                      |
| Leo (team)      | Interaction designer                | Focused on the journey map; interested in the moments where system records and citizen reality diverge                         |
| Alex (team)     | Content designer                    | Compiled the terminology inventory (section 14) and the guidance inventory (section 20)                                        |
| Sam (team)      | Engineer                            | Advises on data timing, batch cycles and what a prototype can plausibly show                                                   |
| Priya Nandra    | Contact-centre operations lead      | Notes seasonal pressure and adviser workarounds; sceptical that digital content changes reach her callers                      |
| Gareth Vale     | Correspondence and print operations | Owns letter generation cycles; notes that letter templates change slowly and centrally                                         |
| Ruth Ockham     | Policy liaison, personal tax        | Advises on what the team may and may not say in guidance; flags that some confusion has policy roots that design cannot remove |
| Dele Awolowo    | Pensions industry liaison           | Explains provider reporting cycles; notes that administrator practices vary widely and are outside HMRC influence              |
| Frances Keel    | Accessibility specialist            | Reviewed prior artefacts; contributed section 11 material                                                                      |
| Tomas Zielinski | Data and analytics                  | Produced the contact-volume analysis in section 13; notes the limitations recorded there                                       |
| Meredith Plume  | Programme board sponsor             | Interested in whether the life-event framing produces different conclusions than channel-by-channel reporting                  |

Standing stakeholder dynamics worth a new joiner knowing:

- Operational stakeholders and digital stakeholders read the same contact volumes differently — as workload to be resourced, and as demand to be designed away, respectively. Both readings appear in board minutes.
- Policy colleagues have asked the team to distinguish carefully between confusion that better design could address and confusion inherent to the rules themselves. The team has not yet had to draw that line in practice.
- The pensions industry liaison has offered introductions to two scheme administrators for future research; nothing is scheduled.
- The programme board has asked for "early signals" at each monthly report. The team has so far declined to report conclusions it does not believe the evidence supports, and the pack's raw-evidence principle (section 1) reflects that stance.

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## 10. Known operational constraints

The following constraints bound what any near-term service change in this space can do. They are facts about the fictional operating environment, gathered from stakeholder interviews and internal documentation.

- **Batch data cycles.** Pension providers and scheme administrators report payments to HMRC on periodic cycles. A citizen's first pension payment may not be visible in HMRC systems for several weeks after the citizen receives it. Any service that shows "your pensions" shows the position as of the last completed cycle.
- **Tax-code recalculation is automatic and event-driven.** When new income information arrives, codes are recalculated and notification letters generated without human review in the standard path. The triggering event and the citizen's own sense of "what changed" need not coincide in time.
- **Letter operations are centralised and slow to change.** Letter templates are shared across many citizen situations; a wording change for the retirement cohort would change letters for other cohorts too, and template release cycles run quarterly at best.
- **Telephony capacity is planned seasonally.** Adviser rosters are set against forecast demand driven primarily by the tax-year calendar. Demand shifts originating in life events rather than the fiscal calendar are harder for the planning model to anticipate.
- **Identity verification thresholds are fixed elsewhere.** The sign-in and verification standards for the personal tax account are set by cross-government arrangements the team cannot vary. Any prototype journey that begins with sign-in inherits the verification drop-off as a boundary condition.
- **Adviser systems show a different view from citizen-facing screens.** Advisers work from internal records whose field names, groupings and update timing differ from what the citizen sees online. Call-listening notes (section 8.2) record the practical consequences.
- **Legacy record structure.** Income records are organised by source and by tax year, not by life event. Assembling a "retirement view" means joining records that were never designed to be joined, with edge cases (duplicate employments, dormant sources) that require manual resolution.
- **Change freezes.** Substantial periods around the start and end of the tax year are closed to production changes. Alpha and any subsequent build must plan around these windows.

None of these constraints is absolute over a long horizon, but all are fixed for the horizon of the current exploration and the first alpha.

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## 11. Accessibility considerations

Accessibility work to date consists of a specialist review of the existing touchpoints (Frances Keel, section 9) and accessibility-focused recruitment in prior research rounds. Findings and standing considerations, recorded for the incoming designer:

- **The cohort has a higher-than-average prevalence of access needs.** Sight, hearing, dexterity and cognitive changes all rise with age. Any service in this space must treat assistive-technology use and non-digital routes as core paths, not edge cases.
- **Letters are an accessibility surface.** For citizens using screen magnification or with low vision, print letters in standard formats are a barrier; alternative-format requests exist but must be set up per citizen and are not consistently offered. The review flagged that the alternative-format route is itself only discoverable in standard print.
- **Cognitive load compounds across the journey.** The review noted that individually acceptable pages and letters accumulate into a demanding whole: multiple senders, multiple reference numbers, and multiple vocabularies (see section 14) each add load. This observation concerns the aggregate journey and was not attached to any single artefact.
- **Telephone menus assume topic vocabulary.** Reaching the right adviser requires choosing between menu options phrased in administrative categories. The review recorded that citizens whose need is circumstance-shaped ("my husband has just retired") must translate it into topic-shaped options under time pressure.

- **Session timeouts and verification steps** disproportionately affect citizens who read slowly, use assistive technology, or need to fetch paperwork mid-task. Prior research recorded abandoned sign-in attempts resumed days later or not at all.
- **Research practice.** All future rounds should include participants with access needs by default; the recruitment specification maintained by Maya includes quotas. Prototype materials must be testable with screen readers before sessions, not after.

The review made no findings about the prototype itself, which did not exist at the time. Its recommendations are held in the project files; the two carried into the current phase are the default inclusion of access-need participants in research and the treatment of letters as in-scope service surface.

## 12. Digital exclusion considerations

Digital exclusion in this life event is treated as a spectrum of circumstances rather than a binary. Desk research and prior rounds contribute the following, recorded without synthesis:

- In the modelled population aged 60 to 75, an estimated 13 per cent have not used the internet in the last three months, and a further estimated 19 per cent use it only for a narrow set of familiar tasks. Both figures are fictional modelling estimates with wide uncertainty.
- Exclusion is situational as well as personal. Prior research includes participants who are confident online in familiar domains but hand anything "official" to a family member; participants with good devices and poor connectivity; and participants whose exclusion began with a single bad experience of an official website years earlier, recounted in detail.
- Intermediary use is common and largely invisible to HMRC. Adult children complete tasks in parents' accounts; advice-organisation volunteers sit beside citizens in libraries; one prior participant's "IT department" was a neighbour. Records show the citizen acting; the acting party is someone else. The team holds no evidence on how widespread this is.
- Phone-first behaviour is not the same as exclusion. Prior rounds include citizens who use smartphones daily yet choose the telephone for anything involving money and officialdom. The team has recorded the behaviour in several forms without establishing its drivers.
- Paper-first citizens experience the journey on the slowest data cycle: their view of their own position is only ever as current as the last letter.
- Assisted digital provision exists (webchat, telephone support for online tasks) but its discoverability was flagged in the accessibility review: the routes to help with online services are mostly online.

The team's working position is that non-digital routes are permanent features of this life event, not transitional gaps, and any concept the exploration produces must state explicitly how it serves citizens who never touch the digital version.

## 13. Contact-channel context

Citizens in this life event reach HMRC by telephone, webchat and post, in that order of volume. The analytics team (Tomas Zielinski, section 9) produced a contact-volume analysis for a modelled cohort of citizens moving through the transition, aligning each citizen's contact history to their own journey moments rather than to calendar months. Volumes are indexed: 100 represents the cohort's average monthly contact rate across the full observation window. The analysis covers volumes only. Reason-for-contact coding was not applied consistently across sites and periods in the source data, so reasons are not categorised here and no reason breakdown accompanies the table.

| Journey moment (cohort-aligned month) | Telephone (indexed) | Webchat (indexed) | Post (indexed) |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------|-------------------|----------------|
| 12 months before State Pension age    | 84                  | 71                | 66             |
| 6 months before State Pension age     | 97                  | 88                | 74             |
| 3 months before State Pension age     | 118                 | 102               | 89             |

| Journey moment (cohort-aligned month)        | Telephone (indexed) | Webchat (indexed) | Post (indexed) |
|----------------------------------------------|---------------------|-------------------|----------------|
| Month of final employment payment            | 141                 | 119               | 108            |
| Month of first pension payment               | 293                 | 187               | 164            |
| 1 month after first pension payment          | 217                 | 149               | 171            |
| 2 months after first pension payment         | 158                 | 121               | 139            |
| 3 months after first pension payment         | 127                 | 104               | 118            |
| First end-of-tax-year cycle after retirement | 162                 | 117               | 143            |
| 6 months into established retirement         | 92                  | 83                | 87             |
| 12 months into established retirement        | 78                  | 69                | 72             |

Notes accompanying the analysis, reproduced as supplied:

- The cohort is modelled and fictional; indexing conceals absolute volumes deliberately.
- Repeat contact is counted per contact, not per citizen; the analysis does not distinguish ten citizens calling once from one citizen calling ten times.
- Webchat availability varied across the observation window, so webchat indices are less stable than telephone indices.
- Postal volumes count citizen-initiated letters only; HMRC-generated letters are excluded.
- The analysis stops at volume. The source systems do not record why individual contacts occurred at particular moments, and the analytics team has advised against inferring reasons from timing alone.

Channel characteristics relevant to any future design work: telephone offers resolution-in-conversation and identity verification by dialogue, at the highest cost per contact; webchat offers concurrent handling and transcripts, but is tied to the pages it is attached to; post is universal in reach, slowest in cycle, and the only channel where the citizen controls their own copy of the record. Advisers on retirement-adjacent calls are drawn from general income-tax teams; there is no retirement-specialist line.

## 14. Terminology

During the desk review, Alex (content designer) collated the terms in use across the fictional guidance corpus, letter templates, screen copy and scheme communications encountered in the project's material. The inventory below records what was observed. No style decision has been taken, and this table is an observation log, not a style guide.

| Concept                                 | Terms observed in use                                                   | Where each was observed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Money received from pensions            | "pension income";<br>"retirement income";<br>"income from your pension" | "pension income" in most tax guidance items; "retirement income" in planning-stage items and one letter template; "income from your pension" in screen copy within the personal tax account                                                               |
| The code governing tax deduction        | "tax code"; "PAYE code"                                                 | "tax code" in citizen-facing guidance and letters; "PAYE code" in two guidance items, adviser-facing material, and one letter paragraph that otherwise says "tax code"                                                                                    |
| An individual pension holding           | "pot"; "scheme"; "plan"                                                 | "pot" in newer guidance and planning tools; "scheme" in workplace-pension items and all scheme correspondence; "plan" in personal-pension items and provider letters; one consolidation item uses "pot" and "plan" for the two sides of the same transfer |
| The statement of expected State Pension | "State Pension forecast";<br>"pension statement"                        | "State Pension forecast" in the forecast service and related guidance; "pension statement" in two older guidance items and, separately, as schemes' name for their own annual statements                                                                  |
| Ceasing work                            | "retiring"; "stopping work";<br>"leaving your job"                      | "retiring" in planning items; "stopping work" in items covering health-driven and early exits; "leaving your job" in employment-focused items that retirement journeys also pass through                                                                  |

| Concept                    | Terms observed in use                                       | Where each was observed                                                                                             |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The yearly scheme document | "annual statement"; "yearly statement"; "benefit statement" | Varies by scheme administrator; all three forms appear in paperwork participants brought to prior research sessions |

Additional observations recorded with the inventory:

- Term choice tracks the authoring team and era of each item rather than any citizen-facing distinction; items written in the same month by different teams differ, and items on the same page have differed between sections.
- Scheme and provider communications, which HMRC does not control, add further variants beyond this table, and citizens encounter HMRC vocabulary and scheme vocabulary side by side in the same week's post.
- The inventory is of terms as used; it does not record how citizens themselves speak. Prior research transcripts contain citizen-side vocabulary ("my works pension", "the tax people", "my book" for a statement) that appears in no official material.
- Where a concept has both a general and a technical term, letters have been observed to switch between them within one document.

## 15. Current assumptions

The team maintains an assumptions register. Assumptions are statements the team or its stakeholders currently act upon; the register records where each came from and how well evidenced it is. The register is reviewed at each monthly report. Status categories: **untested** (no direct evidence either way), **partially evidenced** (some supporting evidence, incomplete or one-source), **contested** (evidence points both ways).

| Assumption                                                                                            | Origin                                              | Evidence status                                                                                                              |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Citizens struggle to find relevant information online                                                 | Stakeholder workshops; adviser anecdote             | Untested — anecdotal only; no direct evidence gathered on findability to date                                                |
| The period around the first pension payment is a natural moment for support                           | Contact-volume analysis (section 13)                | Partially evidenced — volumes only; nothing in the register's evidence base explains the pattern                             |
| Most citizens approaching retirement hold more than one pension pot                                   | Desk research; modelled estimate (section 2)        | Partially evidenced — modelling estimate, not confirmed in a representative sample                                           |
| Citizens prefer digital self-service where a digital route exists                                     | Directorate strategy documents                      | Contested — prior research includes both digital-first and deliberate phone-first behaviour among digitally capable citizens |
| Letters are the most trusted channel for official communication                                       | Correspondence operations stakeholder view          | Untested — no citizen evidence gathered on channel trust                                                                     |
| Citizens understand the difference between the State Pension and their workplace or personal pensions | Implicit in the structure of existing guidance      | Contested — pop-up research (section 8.4) recorded confusion between forecasts and scheme statements                         |
| Improving guidance content will reduce contact demand                                                 | Programme board discussion                          | Untested — no evidence linking content changes to contact volumes in this life event                                         |
| Citizens treat retirement as a single decision point that guidance can address once                   | Implicit in the structure of several guidance items | Contested — lifecycle evidence (sections 4 and 8) shows intermittent engagement over years                                   |

Register practice notes: an assumption is not a finding, and its presence here is not endorsement; assumptions marked untested are candidates for research design in the next phase; and any team member may add an assumption, but only the monthly review may change a status.

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## 16. Current success measures

The measures currently reported for the services this life event touches were designed channel by channel, before the life-event framing existed. They are recorded here because any future concept will initially be judged against them.

| Measure                    | Current definition                                               | Known limitations recorded by the team                                                                                     |
|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Telephone answer rate      | Percentage of calls answered within the target wait              | Measures access to an adviser, not resolution; blind to why the call was needed                                            |
| Average call-handling time | Mean adviser minutes per call                                    | Treats longer calls as cost; call-listening notes show longer calls sometimes doing reassurance work the metric cannot see |
| Digital completion rate    | Percentage of started online transactions completed              | Counts transactions, not goals; a citizen completing three transactions to do one thing counts as three successes          |
| Post-contact satisfaction  | Short survey immediately after telephone or webchat contact      | Measured at the moment of contact; nothing is known about whether the position stayed resolved                             |
| Guidance page views        | Views per item per month                                         | Volume without outcome; a view records arrival, not whether the visit helped                                               |
| First-contact resolution   | Adviser-recorded flag that the query was resolved in one contact | Adviser-judged at call end; repeat contact days later is not linked back                                                   |
| Cost per contact           | Fully loaded cost divided by contact volume, per channel         | Rewards channel shift regardless of citizen outcome                                                                        |
| Letter response rate       | Percentage of letters requiring action that receive the action   | Only letters requiring action are measured; nothing is measured about letters that require none                            |

The team has not proposed replacement measures. A working note from the last monthly report records the open problem: the current measures describe the performance of parts, and the exploration's framing concerns the whole; the team does not yet know what a whole-journey measure of success would be, for HMRC or for the citizen. Section 17 carries the question forward.

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## 17. Known unanswered questions

The team maintains a live list of questions the current evidence base cannot answer. The list is an input to research planning, and items leave it only when evidence answers them. As at the date of this pack:

- Whether proactive prompts or nudges from HMRC at key moments would reduce contact demand, add worry, or both — and for whom. The team's material contains signals in more than one direction and nothing that resolves them.
- What drives the variation in contact volumes across journey moments shown in section 13. The volumes are established; the reasons are not recorded anywhere available to the team.
- How citizens who cannot locate one or more of their pots actually behave over time — whether they trace, abandon, or defer, and what triggers each path.
- Whether phased and part-time transitions produce materially different information needs from cliff-edge retirement, or the same needs on a longer timeline.
- What role family members and informal helpers play across the journey, how often they act on a citizen's behalf, and what they need that the citizen-facing service does not provide.
- Whether the variation in terminology across guidance and letters (section 14) affects citizen comprehension in practice, and if so where it bites.
- How digitally excluded citizens complete the full journey end to end today — the team holds touchpoint-level fragments but no whole-journey account from a phone-and-post-only citizen.
- Whether the first year of retirement is a genuinely distinct phase of need or a tail of the transition, which bears on where any future support should concentrate.

- What "success" means to citizens themselves in this life event — the current measures (section 16) are organisational, and no citizen-defined outcome has been articulated or tested.
- How much of the recorded confusion is addressable by service and content design, and how much is inherent to the underlying rules — the line policy colleagues have asked the team to draw (section 9), which no current evidence locates.

## 18. Risks and dependencies

| Item                             | Type       | Description                                                                                                                               | Current handling                                                                         |
|----------------------------------|------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Small evidence base              | Risk       | The research corpus is early and small; premature synthesis could harden weak signals into design decisions                               | Raw-evidence principle (section 1); assumptions register (section 15)                    |
| Scope drift into policy          | Risk       | Retirement questions shade into pension policy and benefits, which are out of remit                                                       | Remit statement (section 2); policy liaison review of outputs                            |
| Provider data timing             | Dependency | Any concept showing pension information depends on provider reporting cycles the team does not control                                    | Constraint recorded (section 10); engineer advises on what a prototype may honestly show |
| Identity verification            | Dependency | Digital journeys inherit cross-government sign-in standards and their drop-off                                                            | Treated as boundary condition; non-digital routes kept in scope                          |
| Letter template cycles           | Dependency | Any correspondence change moves at quarterly template release speed and affects other cohorts                                             | Early engagement with correspondence operations (section 9)                              |
| Stakeholder interpretation gap   | Risk       | Operational and digital stakeholders read the same volumes differently; board pressure for "early signals" invites over-claiming          | Monthly reporting sticks to evidence status language from the register                   |
| Research fatigue in the cohort   | Risk       | The same citizen circumstances are of interest to several teams across government; over-researched participants produce rehearsed answers | Recruitment specification rotates sources; panel usage capped                            |
| Change freeze windows            | Dependency | Tax-year change freezes constrain build and release timing for any alpha                                                                  | Alpha planning calendars around freeze windows (section 10)                              |
| Terminology ownership            | Risk       | Terms in the inventory (section 14) are owned by multiple content teams; no single owner can decide changes                               | Raised at directorate level; unresolved                                                  |
| Adjacent-department coordination | Dependency | Forecast checking and retirement guidance involve other departments; journey-level changes need their participation                       | Liaison contacts established; no formal joint governance yet                             |

## 19. Service and policy considerations

A holding section for considerations that sit at the boundary of the exploration's remit. None is a finding; each is context the incoming designer should hold when reading the rest of the pack.

- **The tax year is the system's clock; the retirement is the citizen's.** Much of the administrative machinery in this space — reconciliation, statements, code reviews — runs on the fiscal year regardless of when an individual retires. Concepts that follow the citizen's clock will be pulling against the grain of the machinery, and the cost of that pull is unquantified.
- **HMRC is a passenger in parts of the journey it is blamed for.** Scheme decisions, provider paperwork and employer processes shape the citizen's experience, and prior research notes show citizens attributing the whole to "the tax people". Any journey-level intervention inherits accountability for stages HMRC does not operate.
- **Interaction with income-related support.** Some citizens in the cohort receive income-related support administered by another department, and changes in pension income can affect it. The team's remit excludes that support, but citizens' questions do not respect the boundary; prior call-listening included callers asking tax advisers about it.

- **Rules produce some of the recorded difficulty.** Policy liaison (section 9) has flagged that certain recurring points of citizen difficulty follow from the rules themselves — for example, the treatment of a first withdrawal before full records exist — and would persist under any presentation. The register of which difficulties are design-addressable does not yet exist; section 17 records the open question.
- **Precedent from other life events.** Explorations of bereavement and starting work elsewhere in government produced, respectively, a single notification route and a combined starter journey. Both precedents are organisationally attractive and neither has been evaluated against this life event's characteristics — in particular its multi-year arc and intermittent engagement, which differ from both precedents.
- **Trust is asymmetric.** Prior material repeatedly records that citizens weight negative interactions with tax authorities more heavily than positive ones and often narrate a single decades-old incident as governing current behaviour. Any proactive concept operates against that asymmetry, in both directions.
- **The demonstration prototype.** The current phase includes a prototype ("Retirement money check") used as a research stimulus: a signed-in view of a citizen's State Pension forecast and known pots, a plain-language section on what changes when money is taken, and an explained view of the tax code. It is a research instrument, not a committed service; evidence about it lives in the interview artefacts, not in this pack.

## 20. Desk-research inventory

Synthetic guidance inventory for prototype demonstration.

The inventory below records the fictional guidance items reviewed during desk research, as they stand. Items were catalogued as found; overlaps, gaps and inconsistencies are recorded per item without any attempt to resolve them. Journey stages use the lifecycle model in section 4. No item below corresponds to any real guidance product.

| Guidance item                                | Topic                           | User circumstance                                  | Primary action                            | Terminology used                           | Related journey stage                  | Overlap with other guidance                    | Potential source of confusion                                                                                | Notes                                                                         |
|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Plan your income for retirement              | Retirement income planning      | Anyone more than a few years from stopping work    | Estimate future income across all sources | "retirement income", "pot"                 | Early planning                         | Overlaps items 2, 5 and 9                      | Assumes the reader can already list every pot they hold and knows which are workplace and which are personal | Longest item in the corpus; general orientation piece                         |
| Check what your State Pension forecast means | State Pension                   | Citizens within ten years of State Pension age     | Read and interpret a forecast figure      | "State Pension forecast", "pension income" | Early planning; Approaching retirement | Overlaps items 1 and 3                         | Presents a weekly figure where most neighbouring items use monthly or annual figures                         | Carries the caveat that a forecast is not a guarantee                         |
| Understand your pension statement            | Workplace and personal pensions | Anyone receiving an annual statement from a scheme | Interpret an annual statement             | "pension statement", "scheme"              | Early planning                         | Title overlaps item 2; content overlaps item 7 | Title reads as if about the State Pension document but covers scheme statements only                         | Authored by a different content team from item 2, on a different review cycle |

| Guidance item                                  | Topic                 | User circumstance                                                   | Primary action                                           | Terminology used                    | Related journey stage                           | Overlap with other guidance | Potential source of confusion                                                                                                                          | Notes                                                            |
|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tax when you start taking money from a pension | Pension taxation      | Citizens taking a first payment from any pot                        | Understand what tax applies when money is taken          | "pot", "pension income", "tax code" | First year of retirement                        | Overlaps items 6, 8 and 11  | Which half of the page applies depends on whether money is taken as a lump sum or as regular income; the reader must already know which describes them | Highest page views of the corpus in fictional analytics          |
| Combining several small pension pots           | Pension consolidation | Citizens holding two or more small pots                             | Decide whether to bring pots together                    | "pot", "plan"                       | Early planning; Approaching retirement          | Overlaps items 1 and 9      | Uses "pot" for the holdings being moved and "plan" for the receiving product within the same page                                                      | Stops short of advice; signposts to regulated guidance elsewhere |
| Your PAYE code in the year you retire          | Tax codes             | Citizens with employment income and pension income in the same year | Check a code after circumstances change                  | "PAYE code", "retirement income"    | Employment transition; First year of retirement | Overlaps items 4 and 10     | Says "PAYE code" throughout where neighbouring items say "tax code"                                                                                    | One of two items in the corpus using the PAYE form of the term   |
| What your workplace scheme must tell you       | Scheme communications | Members of workplace schemes                                        | Know what statements and letters to expect from a scheme | "scheme", "pension statement"       | Early planning through Established retirement   | Overlaps item 3             | Applies to workplace schemes only; personal pension holders are not excluded until the final section                                                   | Describes obligations that sit with schemes, not HMRC            |
| Tax on money taken flexibly from a pension     | Pension taxation      | Citizens making one-off or variable withdrawals                     | Understand temporary tax positions on early withdrawals  | "pot", "pension income", "tax code" | First year of retirement                        | Overlaps items 4 and 11     | The reader must determine whether their withdrawal counts as flexible access, which the page does not help them do                                     | Cross-links to item 11 for reclaiming                            |
| Tracing a pension you have lost touch with     | Lost pensions         | Citizens who changed jobs and lost scheme paperwork                 | Find current contact details for an old scheme           | "scheme", "pot"                     | Early planning; Approaching retirement          | Overlaps items 1 and 5      | Hands the reader to a tracing service run by another part of government midway through the task                                                        | Traffic spikes follow media coverage in the fictional analytics  |

| Guidance item                                           | Topic              | User circumstance                                             | Primary action                                           | Terminology used                      | Related journey stage                         | Overlap with other guidance       | Potential source of confusion                                                                             | Notes                                                              |
|---------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Income Tax when you have more than one source of income | Multiple incomes   | Citizens with a job plus one or more pensions in payment      | Understand how allowances apply across sources           | "pension income", "tax code"          | Employment transition                         | Overlaps items 4 and 6            | Written for any multiple-income situation; retirement examples appear only in the second half             | Phased retirees arrive here from search more often than from links |
| Claiming back overpaid tax on pension money             | Refunds            | Citizens whose first withdrawal was taxed at a temporary rate | Make a repayment claim                                   | "pension income", "PAYE code"         | First year of retirement                      | Overlaps items 4 and 8            | Offers three claim routes and requires the reader to know which matches how much of the pot was taken     | Second of the two PAYE-form items                                  |
| National Insurance if you work past State Pension age   | National Insurance | Citizens continuing in work beyond State Pension age          | Check which deductions stop                              | "retirement income"                   | Employment transition; Established retirement | Minimal overlap within the corpus | Reads as tax guidance but covers National Insurance only                                                  | Relevant to a minority of the cohort                               |
| Pension contributions while working part-time           | Contributions      | Citizens still paying in during a phased transition           | Check relief on continuing contributions                 | "scheme", "plan"                      | Employment transition                         | Overlaps item 5                   | Aimed at people paying in, but appears alongside taking-money items in search results for phased retirees | Only corpus item addressed to contributors                         |
| Renting out property in retirement                      | Property income    | Retired citizens with rental income                           | Declare additional income                                | "retirement income"                   | Established retirement                        | Minimal overlap within the corpus | Appears in retirement-related search journeys whether or not the reader has property income               | Plausible arrival point from general retirement searches           |
| Tax on savings interest for pensioners                  | Savings            | Citizens with savings interest alongside pension income       | Check whether savings interest is taxable                | "pension income", "retirement income" | Established retirement                        | Overlaps item 10                  | Uses both income terms interchangeably within the same paragraph                                          | Shortest item in the corpus                                        |
| Passing on a pension when someone dies                  | Bereavement        | Family members of a deceased scheme member                    | Notify schemes and understand what beneficiaries receive | "pot", "scheme"                       | Established retirement                        | Minimal overlap within the corpus | Frequently reached from retirement-planning searches although it concerns bereavement administration      | Interacts with guidance owned by other parts of government         |

| Guidance item                          | Topic            | User circumstance                                     | Primary action                                 | Terminology used                           | Related journey stage  | Overlap with other guidance       | Potential source of confusion                                           | Notes                                                      |
|----------------------------------------|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Moving abroad after you retire         | International    | Citizens intending to retire outside the UK           | Understand payment and tax arrangements abroad | "State Pension forecast", "pension income" | Established retirement | Overlaps item 2                   | Refers to "your forecast" when describing a payment already in progress | Relevant to a small minority with complex questions        |
| Help if you cannot use online services | Assisted digital | Citizens without internet access or confidence online | Find telephone and paper alternatives          | "tax code"                                 | All stages             | Minimal overlap within the corpus | The page describing non-online routes is itself online                  | Referenced by advice organisations in prior research notes |

Cataloguing notes recorded at the time of the review, reproduced without amendment:

- Items were reviewed as a citizen would encounter them, entering from search rather than from any index page; the corpus has no single entry point.
- Several items assume knowledge the citizen may not have — how many pots they hold, which kind each is, how a withdrawal is classified — before the item's content can be applied to their situation; the circumstance and confusion columns record these per item.
- Topic overlap between items is extensive and terminology varies between overlapping items; both features are recorded per item above and inventoried by concept in section 14.
- Ownership of the items spans four fictional content teams on independent review cycles; no item records which circumstances it does not cover.
- The inventory records the corpus as found at review date. Items change on their owners' cycles, and the inventory is not maintained continuously.